

# **ALY 6060 Decision Support and Business Intelligence**

## **Module 3 – Working with Business Partners**

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## **PART 1**

### **1. Define Business Partner**

A business partner refers to an individual, organization, or entity that collaborates with a company to achieve shared business objectives. Business partners can include suppliers, customers, contractors, or internal stakeholders (e.g., HR or IT teams operating under a "business partner" model). “A business partnership is a way of organizing a company that is owned and sometimes run by two or more people or entities.” The partners share in the profits or losses. (The Balance Money, Sep 29, 2024) This concept is often used to foster closer alignment and collaboration between different functions, with an emphasis on shared responsibility for achieving strategic goals.

In an organizational context, an HR or IT business partner operates as a strategic advisor to business units, ensuring that their respective areas (e.g., talent management or technology) align with and support broader business objectives. “A business partnership is a legal relationship that is most often formed by a written agreement between two or more individuals or companies. The partners invest their money in the business, and each partner benefits from any profits and sustains part of any losses.” (The Balance Money, Sep 29, 2024)

“Finding a business partner is easy, but finding the right business partner is difficult. Neither party goes into a business relationship with the intent of failure. Unfortunately, it happens way too often.” (Entrepreneur, Mar 21)

### **2. Reasons Why the Business Partner Concept Might Fail**

- a. Lack of Strategic Alignment:** If the business partner's objectives are not aligned with the overarching goals of the organization, their contributions may be seen as irrelevant or unhelpful. “End goals can change as well. A few years into the business, one party may want to remove themselves, so ensure that you cover how you're going to deal with these possible scenarios.” (Entrepreneur, Mar 21). For eg. An HR business partner focuses on compliance rather than aligning talent strategies with growth objectives.
- b. Ineffective Communication:** Miscommunication or lack of clear communication between the business partner and the organization can lead to misunderstandings about roles,

expectations, and deliverables. For eg. An IT business partner fails to communicate technical limitations, resulting in unrealistic expectations.

- c. **Insufficient Expertise:** Business partners must possess deep knowledge of their domain and an understanding of the business they are supporting. A lack of expertise undermines their ability to provide strategic value. “Average performance doesn't cut it in business anymore. Both parties should have a high level of performance to give the business the best chances of thriving. The environment is way too competitive to keep underperforming businesses afloat. For the business to perform at its best, both partners need to be performing at their best.” (Entrepreneur, Mar 21). For eg. An HR business partner without knowledge of industry trends may struggle to design effective workforce strategies.
- d. **Resistance to Change:** Employees and managers may resist the business partner model due to unfamiliarity or fear of losing autonomy, creating friction in collaboration. For eg. A finance team might resist input from an external accounting partner due to perceived micromanagement.
- e. **Overlapping Roles and Responsibilities:** Ambiguities in roles between the business partner and other team members can lead to duplication of efforts, inefficiencies, or conflicts. For eg. An internal IT team and an external IT business partner both attempt to manage cybersecurity without clear delineation of tasks.
- f. **Lack of Trust and Credibility:** Without trust and credibility, the business partner's advice and contributions may be ignored or undervalued. “For any relationship to work, it requires trust. When it comes to business, even greater trust is required. You're not just dealing with your own life, you're dealing with the lives of your employees and clients as well.” (Entrepreneur, Mar 21). For eg. A business partner who fails to deliver on promises loses the confidence of the business unit.
- g. **Inadequate Resources and Support:** Business partners require sufficient resources, tools, and support to be effective. Underfunding or understaffing can lead to suboptimal performance. For eg. An under-resourced HR business partner is unable to provide timely recruitment solutions during a hiring surge.
- h. **Failure to Understand Business Needs:** A business partner who does not fully understand the specific needs and challenges of the business unit may offer irrelevant or impractical

solutions. For eg. An IT business partner implements a system without considering user requirements, leading to low adoption rates.

The business partner concept can fail if there is misalignment between the partner's role and the organization's expectations, inadequate communication, or a lack of resources and expertise. To succeed, business partners must foster trust, demonstrate strategic value, and align closely with organizational goals, supported by effective collaboration and communication.

### **3. Tactics to Overcome Challenges in the Business Partner Concept**

#### **a. Building Trust and Credibility Through Regular Engagement:**

To address the challenge of a lack of trust and credibility, business partners can establish a practice of regular engagement with stakeholders. This involves frequent check-ins, transparent communication about progress and setbacks, and delivering measurable results that align with organizational goals. According to Covey (2006), trust is built through consistent behavior that demonstrates reliability, competence, and authenticity. By actively involving stakeholders in decision-making processes and showing a deep understanding of their needs, business partners can gain confidence and solidify their role as valued collaborators.

#### **b. Providing Ongoing Training and Development:**

A lack of expertise can hinder a business partner's ability to align their services with organizational objectives. To overcome this, organizations should invest in continuous training programs that enhance business partners' technical and strategic capabilities. These programs should cover not only domain-specific knowledge but also leadership, communication, and problem-solving skills. As suggested by Garvin (1993), learning organizations that prioritize skill development and knowledge sharing are better equipped to adapt to dynamic business environments. By empowering business partners with the skills needed to navigate complex challenges, organizations can maximize their contributions and effectiveness.

## PART 2

### Introduction:

This Qlik dashboard provides a comprehensive analysis of the top CEOs from Fortune 500 companies, offering insights into various dimensions of their organizations and leadership. The dashboard focuses on key metrics, such as revenues, number of employees, sector representation, and gender distribution. It also explores the relationship between organizational features, such as headquarters location, the presence of female CEOs, and whether the CEO is a company founder. This visual representation aims to highlight patterns and trends among these leading executives and their companies.

### Summary:

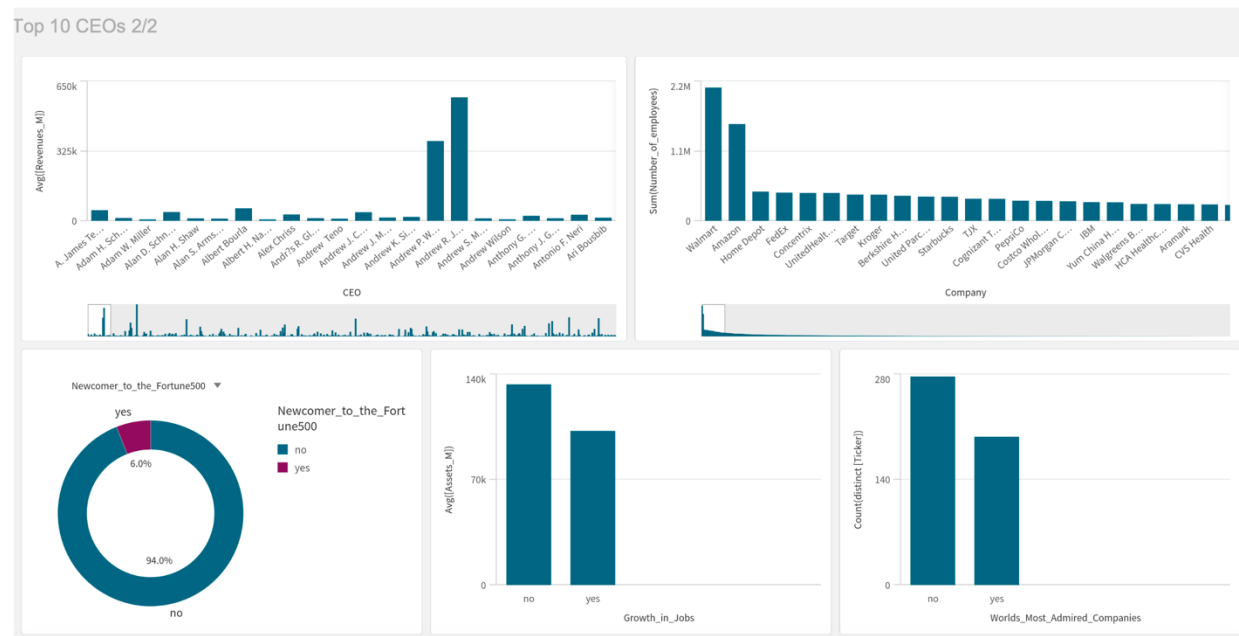
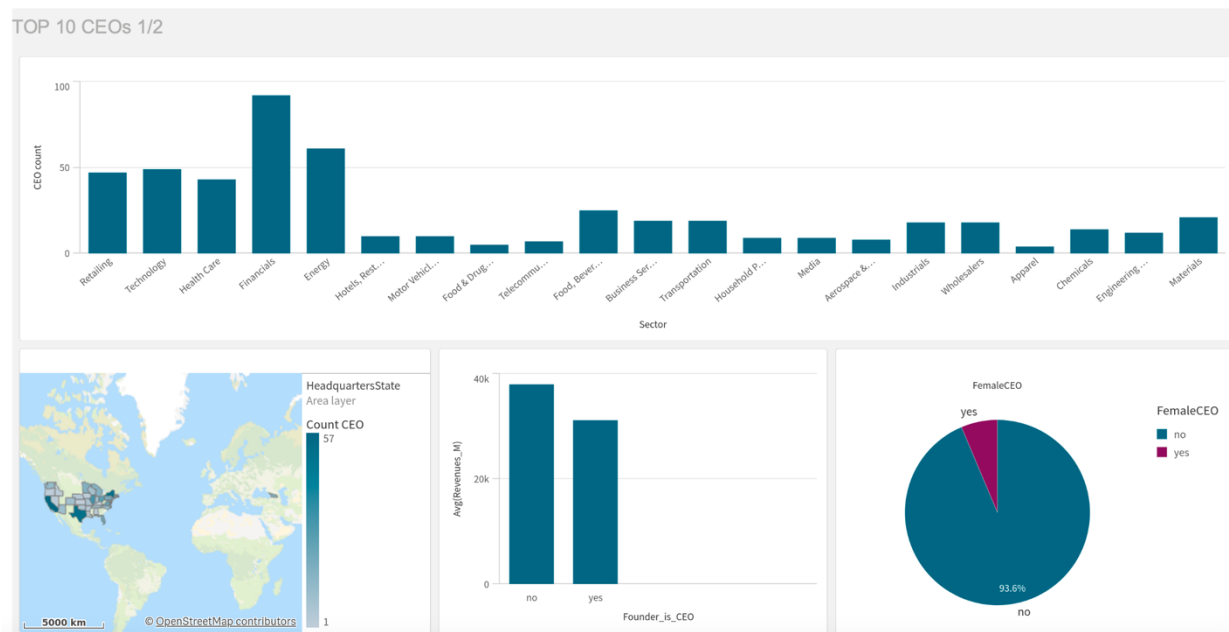
1. **Sector Representation:** The financial sector dominates the representation of CEOs, followed by energy and retail, indicating the prominence of these industries in the Fortune 500 list.
2. **Female CEOs:** Only 6.4% of CEOs are women, underscoring the gender disparity in executive leadership.
3. **Company Metrics:** Walmart and Amazon lead in the number of employees, reflecting their massive operational scales.
4. **Revenue and Founder Relationship:** Companies with non-founder CEOs tend to have slightly higher average revenues compared to those with founder CEOs.
5. **Geographic Insights:** The map visual identifies the concentration of company headquarters across the United States, with states like California and Texas featuring prominently.
6. **Growth and Admiration:** Companies categorized as newcomers to the Fortune 500 or recognized among the "World's Most Admired Companies" show significant growth and distinct patterns in assets and job creation.

### Conclusion:

The dashboard provides actionable insights into the characteristics of top CEOs and their organizations. It highlights the ongoing gender gap in leadership, the dominance of specific sectors, and the geographic clustering of headquarters. These insights can guide discussions on diversity, industry trends, and strategic planning. Future analyses could delve deeper into

correlations between CEO attributes and organizational success metrics, such as profitability or innovation rates.

## Appendix



## References

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